

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 3: Breaking Limits

Day 15 Since Awakening

Hayami woke up at 5 AM without an alarm, their body having adapted to the brutal routine of daily quests. They swung their legs out of bed and stood—then paused, startled by how easy it felt.

Two weeks ago, getting out of bed had been a production. Now they just... stood. No groaning, no stiffness, no feeling like their body was made of lead.

They looked down at their hands, flexing their fingers experimentally. The muscle definition was subtle but visible. Their arms, which had always been on the skinny side, now had actual shape to them. Not bulky—Hayami's frame was naturally lean—but defined. Functional.

[STATS]

- Strength: 23 (+14 from base)
- Agility: 25 (+14)
- Vitality: 22 (+14)
- Intelligence: 27 (+14)
- Sense: 24 (+14)

Fourteen days of daily quests. Fourteen stat increases. The numbers looked small on the screen, but the effects were anything but.

Hayami walked to the bathroom and caught their reflection in the mirror. Same face—pale skin, green eyes, blonde hair perpetually messy from the wolf cut that desperately needed a trim. But something was different. They looked... healthier. Less like someone who survived on convenience store bentos and three hours of sleep. Their eyes were clearer. Their skin had lost that grayish tinge of exhaustion.

They'd always been 173 cm, but now they actually looked it. Like their body had finally decided to inhabit its full height instead of slouching through existence.

"Huh," Hayami said to their reflection.

The daily quest notification blinked to life:

[DAILY QUEST: FOUNDATION TRAINING]

Time to get to work.

The push-ups were almost easy now. Not comfortable—one hundred push-ups would never be comfortable—but manageable. Hayami's form had improved dramatically from those first shaky attempts. Their arms no longer trembled. Their core stayed tight. They moved through the reps with something approaching efficiency.

(50/100)

This was what the increased stats meant. Not flashy superpowers or dramatic transformations. Just competence. The ability to do things that would have been impossible fifteen days ago.

(100/100) ✓

Hayami moved on to sit-ups, their mind already drifting to the Training Manual. They'd been working through it every night after completing the daily quest, and the progress was addictive. The lightning sphere that had lasted three seconds on day one now maintained for forty-five seconds. They could form it with barely a thought, the electricity responding to their will like an extension of their own body.

But the Manual had more advanced exercises. Techniques they hadn't tried yet because they'd seemed too difficult, too far beyond their capabilities.

Maybe it was time to try.

(100/100) ✓

The squats burned in the best way—the burn of muscles that were getting stronger, not breaking down. Hayami counted down mechanically, their thoughts already on the lightning training ahead.

(100/100) ✓

The run was routine now. Hayami's route took them through the park, around the pond, past the old man who sat on the same bench every morning and always called out encouragement. Their pace had increased noticeably over two weeks. What had been a desperate slog was now just... running.

(10.0/10 km) ✓

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!]

[+1 to all stats]

[Random Reward Box obtained!]

Hayami opened the box immediately:

[Item Acquired: Skill Book - Basic Lightning Strike]

Their heart skipped. A skill book. The Association sold these for anywhere from ¥500,000 to several million yen, depending on the skill. And the System had just given them one for free.

They opened their inventory and selected the skill book. It materialized in their hands—a thin volume bound in yellow leather, crackling with contained energy. The moment they opened it, the knowledge flooded in.

[SKILL LEARNED: BASIC LIGHTNING STRIKE] [Description: Channel lightning through your body and release it as a focused strike. Deals 150% of your Elemental Attack as damage. Costs 30 Mana. Cooldown: 10 seconds.]

[MANA: 270/270] (Based on Intelligence stat)

Hayami stared at their new status window. They had a combat skill now. An actual attack. They were still E-rank, still weak compared to real combat Hunters, but they weren't helpless anymore.

The Training Manual sat on their desk, bookmarked at "Exercise 7: Lightning Projection." They'd been working up to it for days.

Time to get serious.

Hayami's apartment building had a roof access that technically wasn't supposed to be used, but the lock was broken and no one cared enough to fix it. They'd started coming up here for lightning practice after the neighbor below complained about "weird electrical sounds" at midnight.

The Tokyo skyline stretched out around them, the morning sun painting everything in shades of gold and gray. Hayami stood in the center of the roof, Training Manual open to Exercise 7.

"Lightning seeks the path of least resistance, but a true master can guide the bolt wherever they will. To project lightning is to impose your will upon the natural order. Begin with a target no more than three meters away. Form the charge within your core, let it travel through your meridians, and release through your dominant hand with focused intent."

Hayami had set up a practice target—an old cardboard box weighted down with rocks. Three meters away. Should be simple.

They raised their right hand, palm out, and concentrated. The electricity gathered in their chest, that familiar tingle that had become almost comforting. They guided it down their arm, feeling it flow through pathways that hadn't existed before their Awakening.

The lightning wanted to discharge immediately. Wanted to leap and crackle and dissipate. Hayami held it, compressed it, aimed it.

Release.

A bolt of blue-white electricity shot from their palm, crossed the distance in a fraction of a second, and struck the cardboard box. The impact was accompanied by a sharp crack and the smell of ozone. The box smoldered.

[SKILL PROFICIENCY INCREASED] [Lightning Manipulation: E-Rank → E-Rank (23%)]

Hayami stared at their hand, then at the box, then back at their hand. They'd done it. Projected lightning across distance. Actually weaponized their ability.

They tried again. And again. By the tenth attempt, the bolt flew straighter. By the twentieth, they could hit a specific spot on the box. By the thirtieth, they didn't even need to think about the process.

The Training Manual had a note at the bottom of the page: *"Proficiency comes from repetition. Mastery comes from understanding. Do not confuse the two."*

Hayami moved on to Exercise 8.

Day 18 Since Awakening

The daily quest had become so routine that Hayami's mind wandered during the exercises. They thought about bills (rent paid, utilities due next week), about food (needed to buy actual groceries instead of convenience store trash), about the next Gate job (three more days until the next available mining position).

They were on push-up number seventy-three when they realized they'd lost count.

Hayami paused, arms locked. Had that been seventy-three or seventy-four? They'd been thinking about whether they could afford a better pickaxe and hadn't been paying attention.

"Shit." They dropped to their knees and checked the quest log.

(74/100)

Okay, seventy-four. They could just finish the remaining twenty-six and—

Wait.

Hayami stared at the counter. They'd definitely done more than seventy-four push-ups. They'd started, gotten distracted, and just kept going. The counter should have shown at least eighty, maybe eighty-five.

Did it cap at one hundred? Did the quest stop counting once they hit the requirement?

Curiosity sparked. Hayami got back into position and kept going.

(75/100)

(76/100)

(77/100)

The counter continued past one hundred.

(101/100)

(102/100)

(103/100)

Hayami's arms were starting to burn now, the comfortable rhythm breaking down into actual effort. But the counter kept climbing. They pushed harder, focused on form, breathing through the pain.

(125/100)

(150/100)

(175/100)

At two hundred push-ups, Hayami's arms were shaking. Their form had deteriorated. But they'd done it—double the required amount.

(200/100)

They tried to do one more. Their arms refused. Okay, that was the limit. Two hundred was the cap.

Hayami collapsed onto their back, gasping. Their shoulders and chest felt like they were on fire. But underneath the pain was a strange sense of accomplishment. Two hundred push-ups. Two weeks ago, they couldn't do twenty.

They moved on to sit-ups, and this time they paid attention. The quest counted up to one hundred, then kept counting. Hayami pushed to two hundred again.

(200/100)

The squats were brutal after the first hundred, but manageable. Two hundred.

(200/100)

The run was where it got interesting. Ten kilometers was the requirement, but Hayami's pace had increased so much that they finished with energy to spare. They kept running.

Fifteen kilometers. Their legs burned but held. They kept going.

Twenty kilometers. This was it. This was the limit. They could feel their body approaching the edge of what it could handle.

(20.0/10 km)

Hayami stopped, hands on knees, gulping air. Their heart hammered against their ribs. Every muscle screamed. But they'd done it.

Double the daily quest requirements. The absolute limit of what their current stats allowed.

The quest completion notification appeared:

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!]

[ACHIEVEMENT UNLOCKED: BEYOND THE LIMIT]

[You have exceeded the Daily Quest requirements by 100%!]

[BONUS REWARDS GRANTED!]

[+3 to all stats] (instead of +1)

[Random Reward Box obtained!]

[Premium Reward Box obtained!]

Hayami stared at the notification, their exhausted brain taking a moment to process. Three stats instead of one. Two reward boxes instead of one. Premium box—that was new.

They'd found an exploit. Or not an exploit, exactly. More like... a hidden mechanic. The System rewarded going beyond the minimum. Rewarded pushing to the absolute limit of your capabilities.

Of course it did.

Hayami laughed, the sound slightly hysterical in the empty park. Of course the System that had been grinding them into the ground with daily quests would reward them for grinding even harder. It was almost funny. Almost.

They opened the standard Random Reward Box first:

[Item Acquired: Intermediate Training Manual (Lightning Element)]

The next level of training. Exercises that built on everything they'd learned so far.

Then they opened the Premium Reward Box, hands actually trembling with anticipation:

[PREMIUM REWARD BOX CONTENTS:]

[Item Acquired: Elixir of Rapid Recovery] [Effect: Instantly removes all fatigue and minor injuries. Restores all HP and Mana. Single use.]

[Skill Book Acquired: Lightning Step] [Description: Channel lightning through your legs to move at superhuman speed for 3 seconds. Costs 50 Mana. Cooldown: 30 seconds.]

[Equipment Acquired: Basic Hunter's Combat Boots] [+5 Agility, +3 Vitality, Enhanced Durability]

Hayami stared at the rewards. This wasn't just better than the standard box—it was exponentially better. A recovery item that would sell for at least ¥100,000. A movement skill that would give them actual combat mobility. Equipment with stat bonuses.

All for pushing twice as hard as the quest required.

They used the Elixir immediately. Warmth flooded through their body, the burning in their muscles fading to nothing. The exhaustion that had been pressing down on them lifted like fog. They felt... incredible. Better than before they'd started the quest.

[HP: 220/220] [MANA: 300/300]

The combat boots materialized on their feet, replacing their worn-out running shoes. They were black leather, reinforced with some kind of flexible material that felt almost alive. Light, comfortable, and significantly more durable than anything Hayami could have afforded.

[STATS] (with equipment bonuses)

- Strength: 26
- Agility: 33 (+5 from boots)
- Vitality: 28 (+3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 30
- Sense: 27

Hayami stood up, and the difference was immediate. They felt lighter, more balanced. The boots enhanced their natural movement in a way that was hard to describe—like the ground itself was helping them move faster.

They absorbed the Lightning Step skill book, and the knowledge flooded in. How to channel electricity through their leg muscles. How to override the body's natural limiters for brief bursts of superhuman speed.

This changed everything.

Day 22 Since Awakening

The routine had evolved. Wake up at 5 AM. Daily quest—doubled. Two hundred push-ups, two hundred sit-ups, two hundred squats, twenty kilometers. Then lightning training with both the Basic and Intermediate manuals.

Then lunch (actual food now, protein and vegetables). Then more lightning training, focusing on proficiency and control. Then dinner. Then review of the manuals and practice with new techniques.

Sleep at 11 PM. Six hours. Repeat.

It was brutal. Exhausting. Consuming every hour of every day.

And Hayami had never been more focused in their life.

[STATS]

- Strength: 30
- Agility: 37 (+5 from boots)
- Vitality: 32 (+3 from boots)
- Intelligence: 34
- Sense: 31

[LEVEL: 7]

[SKILLS]

- Lightning Manipulation (E-Rank → D-Rank: 12%)
- Basic Lightning Strike (Proficiency: 67%)
- Lightning Step (Proficiency: 43%)

The Training Manuals had been revelations. The Intermediate Manual introduced concepts the Basic one had only hinted at—internal mana circulation, elemental resonance, technique chaining. Hayami practiced for hours, feeling their control sharpen with each repetition.

They could maintain a lightning sphere for three minutes now. Could project a bolt accurately up to fifteen meters. Could coat their hand in stable electricity without it discharging.

The Lightning Strike skill had evolved through practice. What started as a clumsy release of energy had become precise, controlled. They could adjust the power output, focus it into a thin lance or spread it into an area effect.

Lightning Step was harder. The skill required split-second timing and perfect mana control. Too much power and they'd overshoot their target. Too little and the boost was negligible. But after four days of practice, they could use it reliably. Three seconds of superhuman speed that turned them into a blue-white blur.

It still wasn't enough.

Hayami stood on the apartment roof, practicing projection against multiple targets they'd set up. They needed to be faster. Stronger. More capable. Because in three days, they had another Gate job scheduled—this time as an actual combat support member, not just mining.

The pay was ¥75,000. The danger was significantly higher. But their stats were approaching the D-rank threshold, and they had actual combat skills now.

They could do this.

They had to do this.

Because the System was training them for something. Every daily quest, every reward, every push beyond the limit—it was all building toward something bigger than harvesting stones in cleared tunnels.

Hayami just had to survive long enough to find out what.

Day 23 Since Awakening

The daily quest completion notification appeared:

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!]

[ACHIEVEMENT: BEYOND THE LIMIT] (9 days in a row)

[+3 to all stats]

[Random Reward Box obtained!]

[Premium Reward Box obtained!]

Hayami had learned to save the Premium boxes. They'd accumulated four of them now, unopened, waiting for the right moment. The Random boxes gave useful items—more training materials, mana potions, basic equipment. But the Premium boxes were special.

They opened today's Random box:

[Item Acquired: Magic Stone (Medium) x5] [Value: ¥25,000 each]

A direct cash reward. ¥125,000 worth of stones they could sell immediately. The System was ensuring they didn't need to take dangerous jobs just to survive.

Hayami added the stones to their inventory and checked their bank account. Between the Gate job payment, their final convenience store paycheck, and selling Random box items, they had ¥284,000. More money than they'd ever had in their life.

Rent was paid through next month. Food was covered. They could afford proper equipment now—a real weapon, better armor, supplies for emergencies.

But more importantly, they could afford to focus entirely on training. No more splitting attention between survival and improvement. Just pure, focused development.

The Training Manuals sat on their desk, bookmarked at increasingly advanced exercises. Lightning Coating. Chain Lightning. Thunder Clap. Techniques that would have seemed impossible three weeks ago.

Hayami cracked open the Intermediate Manual and got to work.

The System wanted them to train seriously? Fine. They'd train until the world acknowledged them as more than just another E-rank failure.

They'd train until the Association's assessment was nothing but a bad joke.

They'd train until "Arbiter of the Primordial Cycle" actually meant something.

Lightning crackled across their fingertips, responding to their will with precision that would have amazed their past self. They guided it into complex patterns, feeling the mana flow through circuits that grew stronger with each repetition.

Outside their window, Tokyo hummed with life. Somewhere, high-rank Hunters were probably relaxing, confident in their power. They'd Awakened strong and stayed strong through occasional training and regular Gate raids.

They didn't need to grind. Didn't need to push past their limits every single day. Didn't need to chase improvement like their life depended on it.

But Hayami did.

Because the System had given them a gift—the ability to grow beyond their starting point. And they were going to exploit it for everything it was worth.

The lightning sphere between their palms pulsed with contained energy, stable and controlled. Three minutes and counting. No sign of destabilization.

Hayami smiled.

Let's see how far this could go.

[END OF CHAPTER 3]